

BEYOND THE CREST

Belmont Crest — Document 04

A Daytime Drama

Founded: Saturday, May 17, 1958 by Alexander & Simone Donohue
Main Gate: 1958 Belmont Crest Parkway NW, Atlanta, Georgia 30327
Home of: The Belmont Crest Country Club (est. 1961)

Where It Is

LOCATION: Belmont Crest is a private, gated community of 1,240 wooded acres on a ridge above the Chattahoochee River at Atlanta's northwestern edge. It sits inside the city limits in Fulton County, ZIP 30327, west of West Paces Ferry Road, with Buckhead's Tuxedo Park just to the east.

Landmark	Address
Main Gate & Gatehouse	1958 Belmont Crest Parkway NW, Atlanta, GA 30327
River Gate (service & security)	40 Riverbend Crest NW, Atlanta, GA 30327
Summit House (Victor & Joan)	1 Summit Crest Drive NW, Atlanta, GA 30327
Belmont Crest Country Club	1961 Fairway Crest NW, Atlanta, GA 30327
Marc-Anthony Bullock's estate	7 Covenant Way NW, Atlanta, GA 30327
The Bullock estate (Robert & Natasha)	22 Covenant Way NW, Atlanta, GA 30327
The Cummings estate	28 Covenant Way NW (three houses down from the Bullocks)
The Olson estate	41 Simone Circle NW, Atlanta, GA 30327
The Baker home	318 Magnolia Ridge NW, Atlanta, GA 30327
The Belmont Academy (K–12)	500 Academy Crest NW, Atlanta, GA 30327
Chapel of the Crest	12 Simone Circle NW, Atlanta, GA 30327

Distance / neighbor	Detail
Downtown Atlanta	About 8 miles southeast (20 minutes without traffic, 50 with it)
Donohue Tower (Midtown)	About 6.5 miles
Tuxedo Park, Buckhead (the Smilleys)	Just across the ridge. The families can see each other's lights at night
Westbrook Academy (Buckhead)	About 3 miles
Chattahoochee River	Belmont Crest's western border. The body of T-Bone Gaines surfaces downstream near the Paces Ferry Road bridge in Ep #0001
Hartsfield-Jackson Airport	About 17 miles south

Belmont Crest Today (January 2026)

- **212 estates** on lots of 2 to 60 acres, about 1,100 residents. Homes rarely sell. When one does, the price starts around \$40 million.
- **The most exclusive address in the South.** Residents include the Donohues, the Bullocks, the Olsons, the Cummingses, the Bakers, two NBA owners, three Grammy-winning producers, a Supreme Court of Georgia justice, and the owners of the South's largest Black-owned bank and construction firm.

- **Security** is run by Blackwater Security International: 140 officers, license-plate readers at both gates, and river patrols.
- **The Crest Covenant** governs everything. Every buyer must be approved by the Belmont Crest Association board of nine. The Donohue family holds two permanent seats, the “Founder's Seats,” and a veto over any sale within sight of Summit House.
- **Summit House** stands at the highest point of the ridge: 42,000 square feet of Georgian Revival, finished in 1960 and designed by the Black architect Eldridge Toussaint, with the famous grand staircase. Everything else in the community lies *beyond the crest*.

History of Belmont Crest

1956–1958: The Ridge

- 1956: Simone Donohue spots the ridge from a riverboat outing on the Chattahoochee. “That’s where our grandchildren will live.” No Black family could buy land there.
- 1957: Alexander forms the Crest Land Trust. A sympathetic white Atlanta attorney, Harlan Whitfield, buys 1,240 acres in eleven parcels as its front.
- Saturday, May 17, 1958: the fourth anniversary of *Brown v. Board of Education*, a date Simone chose. The trust transfers the deed to Alexander and Simone Donohue, and the first stone gate goes up at dawn. Belmont Crest is founded. Theodore is 13, and Victor is 11.
- Summer 1958: Otis Smilley, the Beacon’s press foreman, is fired after Alexander accuses him of selling the paper’s printing plates. Otis swears he was framed. His 15-year-old son Gus never forgets.

1958–1964: The Siege

- 1958–1959: White neighbors sue to void the sale. The Donohues win, because racial covenants had been unenforceable in court since 1948.
- Saturday, November 21, 1959: A cross is burned at the gate. Alexander rebuilds it twice as high with a Beacon headline carved into the lintel: “*THE CREST WILL NOT BE MOVED.*”
- 1960: Summit House is completed and the first twelve families move in: doctors, ministers, a bank president, a Morehouse dean, and two Donohue Records stars.
- 1962: **Otis Smilley**, now running his own print shop, applies to buy a lot. The Association board deadlocks, and Simone casts the deciding vote: no. She never explains why. It is the founding wound of the Smilley–Donohue feud.

1965–1999: The Golden Age

- 1965–1975: Belmont Crest becomes the quiet capital of Black Atlanta. Movement leaders strategize over dinner at the Club, and presidential candidates learn that the road to Georgia runs through Summit House.
- 1969: Victor and Joan’s wedding reception at the Club: 1,400 guests.
- 1974: The Belmont Academy opens. Jasmine Donohue is in its first kindergarten class.
- 1988: The community reaches its limit of 212 estates. The Association closes the ridge to further subdivision, forever.
- 1996: The Smilleys move to Atlanta and buy in Tuxedo Park, across the ridge (see Document 06).

2000–2026: The Third Generation

- 2006: Alexander dies and lies in repose at the Chapel of the Crest while 30,000 people file through the gates.
- Saturday, November 22, 2014: Simone dies at 94, with the reason for her 1962 vote still sealed in her diary.
- 2012: BSI takes over Belmont Crest security.

- Monday, January 5, 2026: Marc-Anthony's 34th birthday gala at Summit House. Series premiere.
- Friday, July 24, 2026 (Ep #0140): The Club votes on the Smilley application, 64 years after Otis was turned away.

The Belmont Crest Country Club

Founded Saturday, June 17, 1961 at 1961 Fairway Crest NW. Alexander built it because Black golfers were still unwelcome at Atlanta's private clubs. It is now among the most exclusive clubs in America.

Feature	Detail
Membership	600 families, by invitation only. Initiation fee \$1.5 million. Annual dues \$120,000
The Summit Course	18-hole championship course along the river bluff. Its 18th green overlooks the Chattahoochee
The Simone Course	9-hole short course and practice academy
The Clubhouse	38,000-sq-ft Georgian clubhouse with the Alexander Ballroom, the Peacock Lounge, and the Terrace
Also	Tennis and pickleball center, equestrian stables and trails, spa, marina on the river, and a private dining room called “The Vault”
Membership Committee Chair	Lucinda Graves, the gatekeeper of the gate
Head Bartender	Malik Freeman, who hears everything

Annual Traditions

Event	When (2026)	Episode
New Year's Day Brunch	Thu, Jan 1	Before the premiere
Valentine's Ball	Sat, Feb 14	#0031
Easter Sunrise Service & Egg Hunt (at Summit House)	Sun, Apr 5	#0063
Juneteenth Jubilee	Fri, Jun 19	#0116
Fourth of July Fireworks on the 18th fairway	Sat, Jul 4	#0126
The Smilley membership vote	Fri, Jul 24	#0140
The Crest Classic golf tournament (Labor Day)	Mon, Sep 7	Season 2
The Crest Cotillion (debutantes)	December	Season 2

Club Rules That Become Story

- A new member needs two sponsors and a majority of the Membership Committee. The Founder's Seat holder, Joan Donohue, votes only to break a tie, which can happen when a member recuses.
- Any member can call for a “Revocation Hearing” against another member for conduct unbecoming.
- What's said in The Vault stays in The Vault. Malik Freeman has never broken that rule. Yet.